

CLINICAL STUDY SERIES

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEETS: TOP 200 DRUGS

By Body System · Landscape Tables · 27 Printable Pages

HOW TO USE

- Print at 100% / "Actual Size" on A4 paper.
- Grouped by body system: class, uses, MOA, side effects and nursing notes.
- Cover a column with paper and quiz yourself, then check.

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Top 200 Drugs

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CARDIOVASCULAR (1/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Apixaban <i>Eliquis</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Factor Xa Inhibitor (DOAC)	AFib stroke prevention, DVT/PE	Directly inhibits factor Xa	Bleeding, bruising	No INR monitoring. Stopping early raises stroke risk. Reversal: andexanet alfa.
Rivaroxaban <i>Xarelto</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Factor Xa Inhibitor (DOAC)	AFib stroke prevention, DVT/PE	Directly inhibits factor Xa	Bleeding, bruising	15 and 20 mg doses with the evening meal. Stopping early raises stroke risk.
Warfarin <i>Coumadin / Jantoven</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Vitamin K Antagonist	AFib, DVT/PE, mechanical valves	Inhibits vitamin K-dependent clotting factors (II, VII, IX, X)	Bleeding, bruising, skin necrosis	Monitor INR (usually 2-3). Consistent vitamin K diet. Antidote: vitamin K.
Aspirin <i>Bayer / Ecotrin</i>	Antiplatelet / NSAID	MI and stroke prevention, pain, fever	Irreversibly inhibits COX, blocking thromboxane	GI bleeding, tinnitus (toxicity)	Avoid in children with viral illness (Reye's syndrome).
Clopidogrel <i>Plavix</i> BOXED WARNING	P2Y12 Inhibitor (Antiplatelet)	ACS, after stents, stroke/MI prevention	Irreversibly blocks platelet ADP receptors	Bleeding, bruising, rare TTP	Poor CYP2C19 metabolizers get less effect. Hold 5 days before surgery.
Metoprolol <i>Lopressor / Toprol-XL</i> BOXED WARNING	Beta Blocker (Beta-1 Selective)	Hypertension, angina, heart failure, post-MI	Blocks beta-1 receptors, lowering HR and contractility	Bradycardia, fatigue, hypotension, masks hypoglycemia	Check apical pulse/BP. Never stop abruptly.
Atenolol <i>Tenormin</i> BOXED WARNING	Beta Blocker (Beta-1 Selective)	Hypertension, angina, post-MI	Blocks beta-1 receptors	Bradycardia, fatigue, dizziness	Renally cleared; adjust in kidney disease. Taper to stop.
Propranolol <i>Inderal</i> BOXED WARNING	Beta Blocker (Non-Selective)	Hypertension, migraine prevention, tremor, anxiety	Blocks beta-1 and beta-2 receptors	Bradycardia, bronchospasm, fatigue, masks hypoglycemia	Avoid in asthma. Do not stop abruptly.
Carvedilol <i>Coreg</i>	Beta Blocker with Alpha-1 Blockade	Heart failure, hypertension, post-MI	Blocks beta-1, beta-2 and alpha-1 receptors	Dizziness, orthostatic hypotension, bradycardia, fatigue	Take with food. Do not stop abruptly.

CARDIOVASCULAR (2/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Nebivolol <i>Bystolic</i>	Beta-1 Selective Blocker (Vasodilating)	Hypertension	Blocks beta-1; releases nitric oxide	Headache, fatigue, bradycardia	Do not stop abruptly.
Amlodipine <i>Norvasc</i>	Calcium Channel Blocker (DHP)	Hypertension, angina	Blocks calcium entry into vascular smooth muscle	Ankle edema, flushing, headache, dizziness	Once daily. Edema is dose-related, not fluid overload.
Nifedipine <i>Procardia / Adalat CC</i>	Calcium Channel Blocker (DHP)	Hypertension, angina, Raynaud's	Relaxes vascular smooth muscle	Edema, flushing, headache, reflex tachycardia	Use extended-release; do not crush.
Diltiazem <i>Cardizem</i>	Calcium Channel Blocker (Non-DHP)	AFib rate control, angina, hypertension	Slows AV-node conduction; relaxes vessels	Bradycardia, hypotension, edema, constipation	Hold for low HR/BP. Many CYP3A4 interactions.
Verapamil <i>Calan</i>	Calcium Channel Blocker (Non-DHP)	Hypertension, angina, SVT, migraine prevention	Slows SA/AV node conduction	Constipation, bradycardia, hypotension	Avoid with beta blockers in heart failure. Increase fiber.
Spironolactone <i>Aldactone</i>	Aldosterone Antagonist Diuretic	Heart failure, hypertension, edema, acne	Blocks aldosterone in the distal tubule	Hyperkalemia, gynecomastia, menstrual changes	Avoid potassium supplements and salt substitutes.
Triamterene / Hydrochlorothiazide <i>Maxzide / Dyazide</i> BOXED WARNING	K-Sparing + Thiazide Diuretic	Hypertension, edema	Blocks sodium channels plus thiazide diuresis	Hyperkalemia, dizziness	Avoid potassium supplements and salt substitutes.
Furosemide <i>Lasix</i> BOXED WARNING	Loop Diuretic	Edema, heart failure, hypertension	Blocks Na/K/2Cl in the loop of Henle	Hypokalemia, dehydration, hypotension, ototoxicity	Monitor K+, weight, I&O. Give IV push slowly.
Torsemide <i>Demadex</i>	Loop Diuretic	Edema, heart failure, hypertension	Blocks Na/K/2Cl in the loop of Henle	Hypokalemia, dehydration, dizziness	Longer-acting than furosemide. Monitor K+ and weight.

CARDIOVASCULAR (3/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Hydrochlorothiazide <i>Microzide</i>	Thiazide Diuretic	Hypertension, edema	Blocks sodium reabsorption in the distal tubule	Hypokalemia, hyponatremia, hyperglycemia, hyperuricemia	Take in the morning. Monitor electrolytes. Sun sensitivity.
Chlorthalidone <i>Thalitone</i>	Thiazide-Like Diuretic	Hypertension, edema	Blocks sodium reabsorption in the distal tubule	Hypokalemia, hyponatremia, hyperuricemia	Longer-acting than HCTZ. Take in the morning.
Ezetimibe <i>Zetia</i>	Cholesterol Absorption Inhibitor	High cholesterol (with or without statin)	Blocks intestinal cholesterol absorption	Diarrhea, joint pain, raised LFTs with statins	Take 2 hr before or 4 hr after bile acid sequestrants.
Fenofibrate <i>Tricor</i>	Fibrate	High triglycerides	Activates PPAR-alpha, increasing fat breakdown	Myopathy (with statins), gallstones, raised LFTs	Monitor kidney function.
Evolocumab <i>Repatha</i>	PCSK9 Inhibitor	High LDL, clinical ASCVD	Antibody that keeps LDL receptors active	Injection-site reactions, nasopharyngitis	Subcut every 2 weeks or monthly.
Atorvastatin <i>Lipitor</i>	Statin	High cholesterol, CV risk reduction	Inhibits HMG-CoA reductase, lowering LDL	Muscle pain, rhabdomyolysis, raised LFTs	Any time of day. Report unexplained muscle pain.
Rosuvastatin <i>Crestor</i>	Statin	High cholesterol, CV risk reduction	Inhibits HMG-CoA reductase	Myalgia, raised LFTs, proteinuria	High-intensity statin. Any time of day. Lower doses in Asian patients.
Simvastatin <i>Zocor</i>	Statin	High cholesterol	Inhibits HMG-CoA reductase	Myopathy, rhabdomyolysis, raised LFTs	Take in the evening. Many CYP3A4 interactions; avoid grapefruit.
Pravastatin <i>Pravachol</i>	Statin	High cholesterol	Inhibits HMG-CoA reductase	Myalgia, raised LFTs	Few CYP interactions compared with other statins.

CARDIOVASCULAR (4/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Lovastatin <i>Mevacor</i>	Statin	High cholesterol	Inhibits HMG-CoA reductase	Myalgia, raised LFTs	Take with the evening meal. Avoid grapefruit.
Prazosin <i>Minipress</i>	Alpha-1 Blocker	Hypertension, PTSD nightmares (off-label)	Blocks alpha-1 receptors, dilating vessels	First-dose syncope, dizziness	Give the first dose at bedtime.
Doxazosin <i>Cardura</i>	Alpha-1 Blocker	BPH, hypertension	Blocks alpha-1 receptors	First-dose syncope, dizziness	First dose at bedtime.
Clonidine <i>Catapres</i>	Central Alpha-2 Agonist	Hypertension, ADHD, withdrawal symptoms	Reduces sympathetic outflow from the brain	Drowsiness, dry mouth, bradycardia	Stopping abruptly causes rebound hypertension.
Hydralazine <i>Apresoline</i>	Direct Arterial Vasodilator	Hypertension, heart failure (with nitrates)	Relaxes arteriolar smooth muscle	Reflex tachycardia, headache, lupus-like syndrome	Often given with a beta blocker.
Isosorbide Mononitrate <i>Imdur</i>	Nitrate Vasodilator	Angina prevention	Releases nitric oxide, dilating veins	Headache, dizziness, hypotension	Needs a nitrate-free period daily. Never with PDE-5 inhibitors.
Lisinopril <i>Zestril / Prinivil</i> BOXED WARNING	ACE Inhibitor	Hypertension, heart failure, post-MI	Blocks conversion of angiotensin I to II	Dry cough, hyperkalemia, angioedema, dizziness	Monitor BP, K+, creatinine. Avoid in pregnancy.
Benazepril <i>Lotensin</i> BOXED WARNING	ACE Inhibitor	Hypertension	Blocks conversion of angiotensin I to II	Dry cough, hyperkalemia, angioedema	Avoid in pregnancy.
Enalapril <i>Vasotec</i> BOXED WARNING	ACE Inhibitor	Hypertension, heart failure	Blocks conversion of angiotensin I to II	Dry cough, hyperkalemia, angioedema	IV form: enalaprilat. Avoid in pregnancy.

CARDIOVASCULAR (5/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Lisinopril / Hydrochlorothiazide <i>Zestoretic</i> BOXED WARNING	ACE Inhibitor + Thiazide	Hypertension	Blocks angiotensin II formation plus thiazide diuresis	Cough, dizziness, electrolyte changes	Monitor K ⁺ , Na ⁺ , creatinine. Avoid in pregnancy.
Losartan <i>Cosair</i> BOXED WARNING	ARB	Hypertension, diabetic nephropathy	Blocks angiotensin II at its receptor	Dizziness, hyperkalemia, hypotension	No ACE-inhibitor cough. Avoid in pregnancy.
Valsartan <i>Diovan</i> BOXED WARNING	ARB	Hypertension, heart failure	Blocks angiotensin II receptors	Dizziness, hyperkalemia, hypotension	Avoid in pregnancy. Monitor K ⁺ and creatinine.
Olmesartan <i>Benicar</i> BOXED WARNING	ARB	Hypertension	Blocks angiotensin II receptors	Dizziness, hyperkalemia, sprue-like diarrhea	Report severe chronic diarrhea. Avoid in pregnancy.
Irbesartan <i>Avapro</i> BOXED WARNING	ARB	Hypertension, diabetic nephropathy	Blocks angiotensin II receptors	Dizziness, hyperkalemia	Avoid in pregnancy.
Losartan / Hydrochlorothiazide <i>Hyzaar</i> BOXED WARNING	ARB + Thiazide	Hypertension	Blocks angiotensin II receptors plus thiazide diuresis	Dizziness, electrolyte changes	Avoid in pregnancy. Monitor K ⁺ .
Sacubitril / Valsartan <i>Entresto</i> BOXED WARNING	ARNI	Heart failure (HFrEF)	Neprilysin inhibitor plus ARB	Hypotension, hyperkalemia, angioedema	36-hr washout after stopping an ACE inhibitor. Avoid in pregnancy.
Amlodipine / Benazepril <i>Lotrel</i> BOXED WARNING	CCB + ACE Inhibitor	Hypertension	Vasodilation plus angiotensin blockade	Edema, cough, dizziness	Avoid in pregnancy.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Alendronate <i>Fosamax</i>	Bisphosphonate	Osteoporosis	Inhibits bone breakdown by osteoclasts	Esophagitis, GI upset, rare jaw osteonecrosis	Empty stomach, full glass of water, stay upright 30 min.
Insulin Glargine <i>Lantus / Basaglar / Toujeo</i> HIGH-ALERT	Long-Acting Insulin	Type 1 and 2 diabetes (basal)	Replaces basal insulin; promotes glucose uptake	Hypoglycemia, weight gain, injection-site lipohypertrophy	Once daily, same time. No peak. Do not mix with other insulins.
Insulin Lispro <i>Humalog / Admelog</i> HIGH-ALERT	Rapid-Acting Insulin	Type 1 and 2 diabetes (mealtime)	Promotes glucose uptake into cells	Hypoglycemia, hypokalemia	Onset ~15 min. Give within 15 min of eating.
Insulin Aspart <i>Novolog</i> HIGH-ALERT	Rapid-Acting Insulin	Type 1 and 2 diabetes (mealtime)	Promotes glucose uptake into cells	Hypoglycemia, hypokalemia	Give 5-10 min before meals.
Insulin Degludec <i>Tresiba</i> HIGH-ALERT	Ultra-Long-Acting Insulin	Type 1 and 2 diabetes (basal)	Replaces basal insulin; lasts over 42 hr	Hypoglycemia, weight gain	Once daily, flexible timing (8 hr apart minimum).
Metformin <i>Glucophage</i> BOXED WARNING	Biguanide	Type 2 diabetes	Decreases liver glucose output; improves insulin sensitivity	GI upset, diarrhea, B12 deficiency, rare lactic acidosis	Take with meals. Hold for iodinated contrast; check kidney function.
Sitagliptin <i>Januvia</i>	DPP-4 Inhibitor	Type 2 diabetes	Increases incretin levels (GLP-1)	Headache, nasopharyngitis, pancreatitis	Weight neutral. Adjust dose in kidney disease.
Tirzepatide <i>Mounjaro / Zepbound</i> BOXED WARNING	GIP / GLP-1 Receptor Agonist	Type 2 diabetes, weight management	Activates GIP and GLP-1 receptors to raise insulin and reduce appetite	Nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, pancreatitis	Weekly injection. May reduce oral contraceptive absorption.
Semaglutide <i>Ozempic / Wegovy / Rybelsus</i> BOXED WARNING	GLP-1 Receptor Agonist	Type 2 diabetes, weight management, CV risk	Boosts glucose-dependent insulin, slows gastric emptying, reduces appetite	Nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, pancreatitis, gallbladder disease	Weekly injection (oral daily). Contraindicated with MTC/MEN2 history.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Dulaglutide <i>Trulicity</i> BOXED WARNING	GLP-1 Receptor Agonist	Type 2 diabetes, CV risk reduction	Increases insulin, slows gastric emptying	Nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, pancreatitis	Once-weekly injection.
Empagliflozin <i>Jardiance</i>	SGLT2 Inhibitor	Type 2 diabetes, heart failure, chronic kidney disease	Blocks renal glucose reabsorption	UTIs, genital yeast infections, dehydration, ketoacidosis	Hold before surgery. Good genital hygiene; stay hydrated.
Dapagliflozin <i>Farxiga</i>	SGLT2 Inhibitor	Type 2 diabetes, heart failure, CKD	Blocks renal glucose reabsorption	Genital infections, UTIs, dehydration, ketoacidosis	Hold before surgery. Stay hydrated.
Glipizide <i>Glucotrol</i> HIGH-ALERT	Sulfonylurea	Type 2 diabetes	Stimulates insulin release from beta cells	Hypoglycemia, weight gain	Take 30 min before breakfast. Do not skip meals.
Glimepiride <i>Amaryl</i> HIGH-ALERT	Sulfonylurea	Type 2 diabetes	Stimulates insulin release from beta cells	Hypoglycemia, weight gain	Take with breakfast. Caution in older adults.
Pioglitazone <i>Actos</i> BOXED WARNING	Thiazolidinedione	Type 2 diabetes	Improves insulin sensitivity via PPAR-gamma	Edema, weight gain, heart failure, fractures	Avoid in heart failure. Monitor weight and LFTs.
Phentermine <i>Adipex-P</i>	Sympathomimetic Anorectic	Short-term weight loss	Releases norepinephrine, suppressing appetite	Insomnia, raised BP and HR, dry mouth	Schedule IV. Short-term use. Avoid with heart disease.
Prednisone <i>Deltasone</i>	Systemic Corticosteroid	Inflammation, asthma flares, autoimmune disease	Suppresses inflammation and immune response	Hyperglycemia, insomnia, mood changes, infection risk, bone loss	Take in the morning with food. Taper long courses.
Prednisolone <i>Millipred / Orapred</i>	Systemic Corticosteroid	Asthma flares, inflammation (liquid for children)	Suppresses inflammation and immune response	Hyperglycemia, mood changes, insomnia	Take with food in the morning.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Methylprednisolone <i>Medrol</i>	Systemic Corticosteroid	Inflammation, allergic reactions, flares	Suppresses inflammation and immune response	Hyperglycemia, insomnia, mood changes	Dose pack tapers over 6 days. Take with food.
Levothyroxine <i>Synthroid</i> BOXED WARNING	Thyroid Hormone	Hypothyroidism	Synthetic T4 replaces thyroid hormone	Tachycardia, tremor, weight loss, insomnia (overdose)	Empty stomach 30-60 min before breakfast. Separate from calcium/iron by 4 hr.
Thyroid (Desiccated) <i>Armour Thyroid</i> BOXED WARNING	Thyroid Hormone	Hypothyroidism	Natural T3 and T4 from porcine thyroid	Palpitations, tremor, insomnia (excess)	Potency can vary more than levothyroxine.

NEURO & PSYCH (1/5)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Amphetamine Mixed Salts <i>Adderall</i> BOXED WARNING	CNS Stimulant	ADHD, narcolepsy	Releases dopamine and norepinephrine	Insomnia, appetite loss, tachycardia, anxiety	Schedule II. Give in the morning. Monitor BP, HR, growth.
Methylphenidate <i>Ritalin / Concerta</i> BOXED WARNING	CNS Stimulant	ADHD, narcolepsy	Blocks dopamine and norepinephrine reuptake	Insomnia, appetite loss, tachycardia	Schedule II. Monitor growth in children. Morning dosing.
Dexmethylphenidate <i>Focalin</i> BOXED WARNING	CNS Stimulant	ADHD	Blocks dopamine and norepinephrine reuptake	Insomnia, appetite loss, tachycardia	Schedule II. Morning dosing.
Lisdexamfetamine <i>Vyvanse</i> BOXED WARNING	CNS Stimulant (Prodrug)	ADHD, binge-eating disorder	Converted to dextroamphetamine; releases dopamine/NE	Insomnia, appetite loss, tachycardia, dry mouth	Schedule II. Capsule can be opened into water or yogurt.
Atomoxetine <i>Strattera</i> BOXED WARNING	Non-Stimulant ADHD Medication	ADHD	Selectively blocks norepinephrine reuptake	Nausea, decreased appetite, suicidal thoughts, liver injury	Not controlled. Takes several weeks to work.
Topiramate <i>Topamax</i>	Anticonvulsant	Seizures, migraine prevention	Blocks sodium channels, enhances GABA	Cognitive slowing, paresthesia, kidney stones, weight loss	Drink plenty of water. Teratogenic; reduces OC effectiveness at high doses.
Levetiracetam <i>Keppra</i>	Anticonvulsant	Focal and generalized seizures	Binds synaptic vesicle protein SV2A	Drowsiness, irritability, mood changes	Few drug interactions. Adjust dose in kidney disease.
Lamotrigine <i>Lamictal</i> BOXED WARNING	Anticonvulsant / Mood Stabilizer	Seizures, bipolar maintenance	Blocks voltage-gated sodium channels	Dizziness, rash, Stevens-Johnson syndrome	Slow titration. Stop and report any rash.
Valproate / Divalproex <i>Depakote</i> BOXED WARNING	Anticonvulsant / Mood Stabilizer	Seizures, bipolar mania, migraine prevention	Increases GABA; blocks sodium and calcium channels	Liver toxicity, pancreatitis, tremor, weight gain	Monitor LFTs and levels (50-100 mcg/mL). Highly teratogenic.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Gabapentin <i>Neurontin</i>	Gabapentinoid Anticonvulsant	Neuropathic pain, postherpetic neuralgia, seizures	Binds calcium channel alpha-2-delta subunit, reducing excitatory signals	Drowsiness, dizziness, edema, ataxia	Taper to stop. Respiratory depression risk with opioids. Adjust in kidney disease.
Pregabalin <i>Lyrica</i>	Gabapentinoid Anticonvulsant	Neuropathic pain, fibromyalgia, seizures	Binds calcium channel alpha-2-delta subunit	Dizziness, drowsiness, edema, weight gain	Schedule V. Taper to stop.
Lithium <i>Lithobid</i> BOXED WARNING	Mood Stabilizer	Bipolar disorder	Alters sodium transport and neurotransmission	Tremor, polyuria, thirst, hypothyroidism	Level 0.6-1.2 mEq/L. Keep salt and fluid intake steady.
Bupropion <i>Wellbutrin</i> BOXED WARNING	NDRI Antidepressant	Depression, seasonal affective disorder, smoking cessation	Blocks dopamine and norepinephrine reuptake	Insomnia, dry mouth, agitation, seizures (dose-related)	No sexual side effects. Avoid with seizure or eating disorders.
Trazodone <i>Desyrel</i> BOXED WARNING	SARI Antidepressant	Depression; off-label insomnia	Blocks serotonin 5-HT _{2A} receptors and reuptake	Sedation, orthostatic hypotension, priapism	Give at bedtime. Priapism is an emergency.
Duloxetine <i>Cymbalta</i> BOXED WARNING	SNRI	Depression, anxiety, neuropathic pain, fibromyalgia	Blocks serotonin and norepinephrine reuptake	Nausea, dry mouth, sweating, raised BP, liver injury	Taper to stop (discontinuation syndrome). Avoid heavy alcohol.
Venlafaxine <i>Effexor XR</i> BOXED WARNING	SNRI	Depression, anxiety, panic	Blocks serotonin and norepinephrine reuptake	Nausea, sweating, raised BP, insomnia	Severe discontinuation symptoms; taper slowly.
Desvenlafaxine <i>Pristiq</i> BOXED WARNING	SNRI	Depression	Blocks serotonin and norepinephrine reuptake	Nausea, sweating, raised BP	Taper to stop.
Sertraline <i>Zoloft</i> BOXED WARNING	SSRI	Depression, anxiety, OCD, PTSD, panic	Blocks serotonin reuptake	Nausea, diarrhea, insomnia, sexual dysfunction	Takes 4-6 weeks. Watch for suicidal thoughts and serotonin syndrome.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Escitalopram <i>Lexapro</i> BOXED WARNING	SSRI	Depression, generalized anxiety	Selectively blocks serotonin reuptake	Nausea, insomnia, sexual dysfunction, QT prolongation	Takes 4-6 weeks. Taper to stop.
Fluoxetine <i>Prozac</i> BOXED WARNING	SSRI	Depression, OCD, bulimia, panic	Blocks serotonin reuptake	Insomnia, anxiety, nausea, sexual dysfunction	Longest half-life SSRI; take in the morning.
Citalopram <i>Celexa</i> BOXED WARNING	SSRI	Depression	Blocks serotonin reuptake	Nausea, sexual dysfunction, QT prolongation	Max 20 mg in patients over 60.
Paroxetine <i>Paxil</i> BOXED WARNING	SSRI	Depression, anxiety, PTSD, OCD	Blocks serotonin reuptake	Sedation, weight gain, sexual dysfunction, anticholinergic effects	Worst SSRI discontinuation syndrome. Avoid in pregnancy.
Mirtazapine <i>Remeron</i> BOXED WARNING	Tetracyclic Antidepressant	Depression	Blocks alpha-2 receptors, increasing serotonin and NE	Sedation, increased appetite, weight gain	Bedtime dosing. Useful when sleep and appetite are poor.
Amitriptyline <i>Elavil</i> BOXED WARNING	Tricyclic Antidepressant	Depression, neuropathic pain, migraine prevention	Blocks serotonin and norepinephrine reuptake	Sedation, dry mouth, constipation, orthostasis	Give at bedtime. Overdose is highly cardiotoxic.
Nortriptyline <i>Pamelor</i> BOXED WARNING	Tricyclic Antidepressant	Depression, neuropathic pain	Blocks norepinephrine and serotonin reuptake	Dry mouth, constipation, orthostasis	Fewer anticholinergic effects than amitriptyline.
Buspirone <i>Buspar</i>	Anxiolytic (5-HT _{1A} Partial Agonist)	Generalized anxiety disorder	Partial agonist at serotonin 5-HT _{1A} receptors	Dizziness, headache, nausea	Not habit-forming. Takes 2-4 weeks. Not for acute panic.
Alprazolam <i>Xanax</i> BOXED WARNING	Benzodiazepine	Anxiety, panic disorder	Enhances GABA-A activity	Sedation, dependence, respiratory depression with opioids	Schedule IV. Taper to stop; withdrawal can cause seizures.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Clonazepam <i>Klonopin</i> BOXED WARNING	Benzodiazepine	Panic disorder, seizures	Enhances GABA-A activity	Sedation, ataxia, dependence	Schedule IV. Long-acting; taper slowly.
Lorazepam <i>Ativan</i> BOXED WARNING	Benzodiazepine	Anxiety, status epilepticus, sedation	Enhances GABA-A activity	Sedation, respiratory depression, dependence	Schedule IV. IV drug of choice for status epilepticus.
Diazepam <i>Valium</i> BOXED WARNING	Benzodiazepine	Anxiety, muscle spasm, alcohol withdrawal, seizures	Enhances GABA-A activity	Sedation, ataxia, respiratory depression	Schedule IV. Very long half-life; fall risk in older adults.
Temazepam <i>Restoril</i> BOXED WARNING	Benzodiazepine (Hypnotic)	Short-term insomnia	Enhances GABA-A activity	Drowsiness, dizziness, dependence	Schedule IV. Take 30 min before bed.
Zolpidem <i>Ambien</i> BOXED WARNING	Nonbenzodiazepine Hypnotic	Insomnia	Enhances GABA-A activity	Next-day drowsiness, complex sleep behaviors	Take right before bed with 7-8 hours to sleep. Lower dose in women.
Quetiapine <i>Seroquel</i> BOXED WARNING	Atypical Antipsychotic	Schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, adjunct for depression	Blocks dopamine D2 and serotonin 5-HT _{2A}	Sedation, weight gain, hyperglycemia, orthostasis	Monitor weight, glucose, lipids.
Aripiprazole <i>Abilify</i> BOXED WARNING	Atypical Antipsychotic	Schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, adjunct for depression	Partial agonist at D2 and 5-HT _{1A}	Akathisia, insomnia, impulse-control problems	Lower metabolic risk than other atypicals.
Olanzapine <i>Zyprexa</i> BOXED WARNING	Atypical Antipsychotic	Schizophrenia, bipolar disorder	Blocks D2 and 5-HT _{2A} receptors	Major weight gain, hyperglycemia, sedation	Monitor weight, glucose, lipids.
Donepezil <i>Aricept</i>	Cholinesterase Inhibitor	Alzheimer's dementia	Increases acetylcholine in the brain	Nausea, diarrhea, bradycardia, vivid dreams	Slows decline; does not cure.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Memantine <i>Namenda</i>	NMDA Receptor Antagonist	Moderate to severe Alzheimer's dementia	Blocks excess glutamate activity	Dizziness, headache, constipation	Often combined with donepezil.
Ropinirole <i>Requip</i>	Dopamine Agonist	Parkinson's disease, restless legs syndrome	Stimulates dopamine receptors	Nausea, sleep attacks, impulse-control disorders	Warn about sudden sleepiness while driving.
Rimegepant <i>Nurtec ODT</i>	CGRP Receptor Antagonist	Acute migraine and prevention	Blocks CGRP receptors	Nausea	Dissolve on the tongue. No vasoconstriction (unlike triptans).
Sumatriptan <i>Imitrex</i>	Triptan (5-HT _{1B/1D} Agonist)	Acute migraine	Constricts cranial blood vessels	Chest tightness, tingling, dizziness	Avoid with CAD or uncontrolled hypertension. Not for prevention.

RESPIRATORY (1/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Benzonatate <i>Tessalon</i>	Antitussive	Cough	Numbs stretch receptors in the lungs	Drowsiness, dizziness; choking if chewed	Swallow whole. Fatal overdose in young children.
Montelukast <i>Singulair</i> BOXED WARNING	Leukotriene Receptor Antagonist	Asthma maintenance, allergic rhinitis, exercise bronchospasm	Blocks leukotriene receptors	Headache, mood changes, nightmares, suicidal thoughts	Evening dosing. Not for acute attacks. Report behavior changes.
Fluticasone (Nasal/Inhaled) <i>Flonase / Flovent</i>	Corticosteroid	Allergic rhinitis (nasal), asthma maintenance (inhaled)	Reduces local airway inflammation	Nosebleeds, oral thrush, hoarseness	Rinse mouth after inhaled use. Not a rescue drug.
Budesonide <i>Pulmicort / Entocort</i>	Corticosteroid	Asthma (inhaled), Crohn's disease (oral)	Local anti-inflammatory effect	Thrush (inhaled), headache	Rinse mouth after inhaled use.
Fluticasone / Salmeterol <i>Advair</i>	ICS + LABA	Asthma and COPD maintenance	Reduces airway inflammation plus long-acting bronchodilation	Thrush, hoarseness, headache	Rinse mouth after use. Not for acute attacks.
Budesonide / Formoterol <i>Symbicort</i>	ICS + LABA	Asthma and COPD maintenance	Reduces inflammation plus long-acting bronchodilation	Thrush, hoarseness, tremor	Rinse mouth after use. Some asthma plans also use it as reliever.
Fluticasone / Vilanterol <i>Breo Ellipta</i>	ICS + LABA	Asthma and COPD maintenance	Reduces inflammation plus long-acting bronchodilation	Thrush, headache, upper respiratory infection	Once daily. Rinse mouth after use.
Fluticasone / Umeclidinium / Vilanterol <i>Trelegy Ellipta</i>	ICS + LAMA + LABA	COPD and asthma maintenance	Anti-inflammatory plus two long-acting bronchodilators	Thrush, headache, upper respiratory infection	One inhalation daily. Rinse mouth after use.
Tiotropium <i>Spiriva</i>	LAMA	COPD and asthma maintenance	Blocks muscarinic receptors in the airways	Dry mouth, urinary retention, constipation	Do not swallow capsules; use with the inhaler device.

RESPIRATORY (2/2)

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Albuterol / Ipratropium <i>Combivent / DuoNeb</i>	SABA + SAMA	COPD bronchospasm	Beta-2 agonist plus anticholinergic bronchodilation	Dry mouth, tremor, tachycardia	Avoid spraying into eyes (glaucoma risk).
Albuterol <i>ProAir / Ventolin</i>	Short-Acting Beta-2 Agonist	Acute bronchospasm, asthma, COPD	Stimulates beta-2 receptors to relax airway muscle	Tachycardia, tremor, nervousness, hypokalemia	Rescue inhaler. Needing it more than 2 days/week signals poor control.

GASTROINTESTINAL

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Ondansetron <i>Zofran</i>	5-HT3 Antagonist (Antiemetic)	Nausea/vomiting (chemo, post-op)	Blocks serotonin 5-HT3 receptors	Headache, constipation, QT prolongation	Check ECG risk factors. ODT dissolves on the tongue.
Famotidine <i>Pepcid</i>	H2 Receptor Antagonist	GERD, peptic ulcer, heartburn	Blocks histamine H2 receptors in the stomach	Headache, dizziness, confusion in older adults	Reduce dose in kidney disease.
Omeprazole <i>Prilosec</i>	Proton Pump Inhibitor	GERD, ulcers, H. pylori (combo)	Irreversibly blocks the gastric proton pump	Headache, diarrhea; long-term: C. diff, fractures, low Mg, low B12	Take 30-60 min before breakfast. Use the lowest effective duration.
Pantoprazole <i>Protonix</i>	Proton Pump Inhibitor	GERD, erosive esophagitis, GI bleed prophylaxis	Irreversibly blocks the gastric proton pump	Headache, diarrhea; long-term low Mg, C. diff	Before breakfast. IV form used in hospital for GI bleeds.
Esomeprazole <i>Nexium</i>	Proton Pump Inhibitor	GERD, erosive esophagitis, H. pylori	Irreversibly blocks the gastric proton pump	Headache, diarrhea; long-term low Mg, fractures	Take at least 1 hr before a meal.
Mesalamine <i>Lialda / Asacol</i>	Aminosalicylate (5-ASA)	Ulcerative colitis	Reduces inflammation in the colon lining	Headache, abdominal pain, kidney injury	Swallow whole. Monitor kidney function.
Polyethylene Glycol 3350 <i>MiraLAX</i>	Osmotic Laxative	Constipation, bowel prep	Draws water into the colon	Bloating, cramping, diarrhea	Mix in 4-8 oz of fluid. Works in 1-3 days.
Docusate <i>Colace</i>	Stool Softener	Constipation prevention	Lets water into the stool	Mild cramping, diarrhea	Does not stimulate the bowel; drink plenty of water.

ANTI-INFECTIVES (1/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Valacyclovir <i>Valtrex</i>	Antiviral (Nucleoside Analog)	Herpes zoster, genital herpes, cold sores	Prodrug of acyclovir; inhibits viral DNA polymerase	Headache, nausea, kidney injury	Start early (within 72 hr for shingles). Stay hydrated.
Acyclovir <i>Zovirax</i>	Antiviral (Nucleoside Analog)	Herpes simplex, shingles, chickenpox	Inhibits viral DNA polymerase	Nausea, kidney injury (IV)	Hydrate well, especially with IV use.
Emtricitabine / Tenofovir <i>Truvada / Descovy</i> BOXED WARNING	NRTI Combination	HIV treatment, HIV PrEP	Blocks HIV reverse transcriptase	Nausea, kidney injury, bone loss	Confirm HIV-negative before PrEP. HBV flare on stopping.
Nirmatrelvir / Ritonavir <i>Paxlovid</i> BOXED WARNING	SARS-CoV-2 Protease Inhibitor + Booster	Mild-moderate COVID-19 in high-risk patients	Blocks viral protease; ritonavir boosts levels	Altered taste, diarrhea	Start within 5 days of symptoms. Check all drug interactions.
Fluconazole <i>Diflucan</i>	Azole Antifungal	Candida infections, cryptococcal meningitis	Inhibits fungal ergosterol synthesis	Headache, nausea, liver injury, QT prolongation	Many interactions (raises warfarin effect).
Cephalexin <i>Keflex</i>	1st-Gen Cephalosporin	Skin infections, UTI, strep throat	Inhibits bacterial cell wall synthesis	Diarrhea, rash	Low cross-reactivity with penicillin allergy; ask about the reaction.
Cefdinir <i>Omnicef</i>	3rd-Gen Cephalosporin	Otitis media, sinusitis, pneumonia, skin infections	Inhibits bacterial cell wall synthesis	Diarrhea, red stools (with iron)	Separate from iron and antacids by 2 hr.
Ofloxacin <i>Floxin</i>	Fluoroquinolone Antibiotic	Ear and eye infections (drops)	Inhibits bacterial DNA gyrase	Local irritation, taste changes (drops)	Systemic fluoroquinolones carry tendon rupture warnings.
Ciprofloxacin <i>Cipro</i> BOXED WARNING	Fluoroquinolone Antibiotic	UTI, GI infections, bone infections	Inhibits bacterial DNA gyrase	Tendon rupture, neuropathy, QT prolongation, C. diff	Separate from dairy, antacids, iron by 2 hr.

ANTI-INFECTIVES (2/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Clindamycin <i>Cleocin</i> BOXED WARNING	Lincosamide Antibiotic	Skin, dental, anaerobic infections	Inhibits bacterial protein synthesis (50S)	Diarrhea, C. difficile colitis, rash	Report severe or persistent diarrhea.
Azithromycin <i>Zithromax</i>	Macrolide Antibiotic	Respiratory infections, chlamydia	Inhibits bacterial protein synthesis (50S)	Diarrhea, nausea, QT prolongation	Short course (Z-Pak). Separate from Al/Mg antacids.
Metronidazole <i>Flagyl</i> BOXED WARNING	Nitroimidazole Antimicrobial	C. diff, bacterial vaginosis, trichomoniasis	Disrupts DNA in anaerobes and protozoa	Metallic taste, nausea, neuropathy	No alcohol during and for 3 days after.
Amoxicillin <i>Amoxil</i>	Aminopenicillin	Ear, sinus, throat, skin infections; H. pylori	Inhibits bacterial cell wall synthesis	Diarrhea, rash, allergic reactions	Ask about penicillin allergy. Finish the full course.
Amoxicillin / Clavulanate <i>Augmentin</i>	Penicillin + Beta-Lactamase Inhibitor	Sinusitis, otitis, bites, skin and respiratory infections	Cell wall inhibitor; clavulanate blocks beta-lactamase	Diarrhea (more than amoxicillin), rash	Take with food to reduce GI upset.
Sulfamethoxazole / Trimethoprim <i>Bactrim</i>	Sulfonamide Antibiotic	UTI, MRSA skin infections, PCP	Blocks bacterial folate synthesis	Rash, SJS, hyperkalemia, photosensitivity	Drink plenty of water. Check sulfa allergy. Raises warfarin effect.
Doxycycline <i>Vibramycin</i>	Tetracycline Antibiotic	Acne, Lyme disease, chlamydia, pneumonia	Inhibits bacterial protein synthesis (30S)	Photosensitivity, esophagitis, GI upset	Full glass of water; stay upright 30 min. Avoid in pregnancy and young children.
Nitrofurantoin <i>Macrobid</i>	Urinary Antibacterial	Uncomplicated UTI	Damages bacterial DNA in the urine	Nausea, brown urine, rare lung or liver toxicity	Take with food. Avoid with poor kidney function.

PAIN & MUSCULOSKELETAL (1/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Tizanidine <i>Zanaflex</i>	Central Alpha-2 Agonist (Muscle Relaxant)	Spasticity	Reduces spinal motor neuron activity	Drowsiness, hypotension, dry mouth, liver injury	Avoid with ciprofloxacin or fluvoxamine. Taper to stop.
Baclofen <i>Lioresal</i>	GABA-B Agonist (Muscle Relaxant)	Spasticity (MS, spinal cord injury)	Activates GABA-B receptors in the spinal cord	Drowsiness, weakness, dizziness	Never stop abruptly (hallucinations, seizures).
Cyclobenzaprine <i>Flexeril</i>	Skeletal Muscle Relaxant	Acute muscle spasm	Acts centrally at the brainstem to reduce muscle tone	Drowsiness, dry mouth, dizziness	Short-term use only. Avoid in older adults (Beers).
Methocarbamol <i>Robaxin</i>	Skeletal Muscle Relaxant	Acute muscle spasm	General CNS depression	Drowsiness, dizziness, dark urine	Harmless urine color change (brown, black, green).
Acetaminophen <i>Tylenol</i>	Analgesic / Antipyretic	Pain, fever	Inhibits prostaglandin synthesis in the CNS	Liver injury in overdose	Max 4 g/day (lower with liver disease or alcohol use). Antidote: acetylcysteine.
Ibuprofen <i>Advil / Motrin</i> BOXED WARNING	NSAID	Pain, fever, inflammation	Non-selectively inhibits COX-1 and COX-2	GI upset/bleeding, kidney injury, raised BP	Take with food. Avoid in late pregnancy and kidney disease.
Diclofenac <i>Voltaren</i> BOXED WARNING	NSAID	Arthritis pain, inflammation (oral and topical gel)	Inhibits COX-1 and COX-2	GI bleeding, liver injury, raised BP	Topical gel has less systemic exposure.
Naproxen <i>Aleve / Naprosyn</i> BOXED WARNING	NSAID	Pain, arthritis, gout, dysmenorrhea	Non-selectively inhibits COX	GI bleeding, kidney injury, raised BP	Take with food. Twice-daily dosing.
Meloxicam <i>Mobic</i> BOXED WARNING	NSAID (COX-2 Preferential)	Osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis	Inhibits prostaglandin synthesis	GI bleeding, kidney injury, edema, raised BP	Take with food. Boxed warning: CV events and GI bleeding.

PAIN & MUSCULOSKELETAL (2/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Celecoxib <i>Celebrex</i> BOXED WARNING	NSAID (COX-2 Selective)	Osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, acute pain	Selectively inhibits COX-2	CV events, GI bleeding (less), edema	Caution with sulfonamide allergy.
Oxycodone <i>Roxicodone / OxyContin</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Opioid Analgesic	Moderate to severe pain	Mu-opioid receptor agonist	Constipation, sedation, respiratory depression, dependence	Schedule II. Never crush ER tablets. Keep naloxone available.
Morphine <i>MS Contin</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Opioid Analgesic	Severe pain	Mu-opioid receptor agonist	Respiratory depression, constipation, hypotension	Schedule II. Never crush ER tablets. Antidote: naloxone.
Tramadol <i>Ultram</i> BOXED WARNING	Opioid Analgesic (Mu Agonist + SNRI)	Moderate to severe pain	Weak mu agonist; blocks serotonin/NE reuptake	Nausea, dizziness, seizures, serotonin syndrome	Schedule IV. Avoid with SSRIs/SNRIs and seizure history.
Hydrocodone / Acetaminophen <i>Norco / Vicodin</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Opioid Combination	Moderate to severe pain	Mu-opioid agonist plus central analgesic	Constipation, sedation, respiratory depression, dependence	Schedule II. Count all acetaminophen (max 4 g/day).
Oxycodone / Acetaminophen <i>Percocet</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Opioid Combination	Moderate to severe pain	Mu-opioid agonist plus central analgesic	Constipation, sedation, respiratory depression	Schedule II. Count total daily acetaminophen.
Allopurinol <i>Zyloprim</i>	Xanthine Oxidase Inhibitor	Gout prevention, tumor lysis prevention	Blocks uric acid production	Rash (stop immediately), SJS, GI upset	Not for acute attacks. Drink plenty of fluids.

WOMEN'S & MEN'S HEALTH (1/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Anastrozole <i>Arimidex</i>	Aromatase Inhibitor	Hormone-receptor-positive breast cancer (postmenopausal)	Blocks estrogen production	Hot flashes, joint pain, bone loss	Monitor bone density.
Etonogestrel / Ethinyl Estradiol <i>NuvaRing</i> BOXED WARNING	Combined Hormonal Contraceptive Ring	Pregnancy prevention	Suppresses ovulation	Vaginal irritation, headache, clots	Leave in 3 weeks, out 1 week. Smoking over 35 raises CV risk.
Norethindrone / Ethinyl Estradiol <i>Loestrin / Junel</i> BOXED WARNING	Combined Oral Contraceptive	Pregnancy prevention	Suppresses ovulation; thickens cervical mucus	Spotting, nausea, clots, raised BP	Smoking over age 35 greatly raises CV risk.
Norgestimate / Ethinyl Estradiol <i>Ortho Tri-Cyclen</i> BOXED WARNING	Combined Oral Contraceptive	Pregnancy prevention, acne	Suppresses ovulation	Spotting, nausea, clots	Smoking over age 35 greatly raises CV risk.
Levonorgestrel / Ethinyl Estradiol <i>Aviane / Seasonique</i> BOXED WARNING	Combined Oral Contraceptive	Pregnancy prevention	Suppresses ovulation	Spotting, nausea, clots	Smoking over age 35 greatly raises CV risk.
Drospirenone / Ethinyl Estradiol <i>Yaz / Yasmin</i> BOXED WARNING	Combined Oral Contraceptive	Pregnancy prevention, PMDD, acne	Suppresses ovulation; drospirenone is anti-mineralocorticoid	Hyperkalemia, clots, spotting	Check K+ with ACE inhibitors or ARBs. Smoking over 35 raises risk.
Norethindrone <i>Camila / Errin</i>	Progestin-Only Contraceptive	Pregnancy prevention (incl. breastfeeding)	Thickens cervical mucus	Irregular bleeding, headache	Take at the same time daily; a 3-hr delay needs backup.
Testosterone <i>AndroGel / Depo-Testosterone</i> BOXED WARNING	Androgen	Low testosterone (hypogonadism)	Replaces testosterone	Acne, polycythemia, raised BP, edema	Gel: cover site and wash hands; avoid skin contact with women/children.
Estradiol <i>Estrace</i> BOXED WARNING	Estrogen	Menopausal symptoms, hypoestrogenism, osteoporosis prevention	Replaces estrogen	Breast tenderness, nausea, clots, stroke	Add progestin if uterus present. Lowest dose, shortest time.

WOMEN'S & MEN'S HEALTH (2/2)

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Progesterone <i>Prometrium</i> BOXED WARNING	Progestin	Endometrial protection with estrogen, amenorrhea	Replaces progesterone	Drowsiness, dizziness, breast tenderness	Take at bedtime. Contains peanut oil.
Finasteride <i>Proscar / Propecia</i>	5-Alpha Reductase Inhibitor	BPH, male-pattern hair loss	Blocks conversion of testosterone to DHT	Decreased libido, erectile dysfunction	Pregnant people should not handle crushed tablets. Lowers PSA.
Tamsulosin <i>Flomax</i>	Alpha-1 Blocker (Uroselective)	Benign prostatic hyperplasia	Relaxes prostate and bladder-neck smooth muscle	Dizziness, orthostatic hypotension, abnormal ejaculation	Take 30 min after the same meal daily. Tell eye surgeon (floppy iris).
Tadalafil <i>Cialis</i>	PDE-5 Inhibitor	Erectile dysfunction, BPH, pulmonary hypertension	Increases cGMP, relaxing smooth muscle	Headache, flushing, back pain	Never with nitrates (severe hypotension). Lasts up to 36 hr.
Sildenafil <i>Viagra / Revatio</i>	PDE-5 Inhibitor	Erectile dysfunction, pulmonary hypertension	Increases cGMP, relaxing smooth muscle	Headache, flushing, blue-tinted vision	Never with nitrates. Seek care for erections over 4 hr.

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Hydroxychloroquine <i>Plaquenil</i>	Antimalarial / DMARD	Lupus, rheumatoid arthritis, malaria	Modulates immune response	Retinal toxicity, GI upset, QT prolongation	Baseline and yearly eye exams.
Methotrexate <i>Trexall / Otrexup</i> BOXED WARNING HIGH-ALERT	Antimetabolite / DMARD	RA, psoriasis, cancers	Folic acid antagonist	Bone marrow suppression, liver toxicity, mouth sores	Weekly (not daily) for RA. Folic acid supplement. Avoid pregnancy.
Cyclosporine <i>Neoral / Sandimmune</i> BOXED WARNING	Calcineurin Inhibitor	Transplant rejection prevention, RA, psoriasis	Inhibits calcineurin, blocking T-cell activation	Nephrotoxicity, hypertension, gum overgrowth	Monitor levels. Avoid grapefruit.
Tacrolimus <i>Prograf</i> BOXED WARNING	Calcineurin Inhibitor	Organ transplant rejection prevention	Inhibits calcineurin, blocking T-cell activation	Nephrotoxicity, tremor, hyperglycemia, hyperkalemia	Monitor trough levels. Avoid grapefruit.
Triamcinolone <i>Kenalog</i>	Corticosteroid (Topical / Injectable)	Skin inflammation (topical), joint injections	Reduces inflammation and immune response	Skin thinning (topical), raised glucose (injection)	Avoid long use on face and skin folds.
Dupilumab <i>Dupixent</i>	IL-4 / IL-13 Blocker (Monoclonal Antibody)	Eczema, asthma, chronic sinusitis with polyps	Blocks IL-4 and IL-13 signaling	Conjunctivitis, injection-site reactions	Subcut every 2 weeks. Avoid live vaccines.
Adalimumab <i>Humira</i> BOXED WARNING	TNF-Alpha Inhibitor	RA, psoriasis, Crohn's, ulcerative colitis	Monoclonal antibody that neutralizes TNF-alpha	Serious infections, injection-site reactions, lymphoma	Screen for TB and hepatitis B first. No live vaccines.

ALLERGY

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Hydroxyzine <i>Atarax / Vistaril</i>	1st-Gen Antihistamine	Anxiety, itching, sedation	Blocks H1 receptors centrally and peripherally	Drowsiness, dry mouth, QT prolongation	Fall risk in older adults (anticholinergic).
Meclizine <i>Antivert</i>	1st-Gen Antihistamine (Vertigo)	Vertigo, motion sickness	Blocks H1 receptors in the vestibular system	Drowsiness, dry mouth	Take 1 hr before travel. Fall risk in older adults.
Cetirizine <i>Zyrtec</i>	2nd-Gen Antihistamine	Allergic rhinitis, hives	Blocks peripheral H1 receptors	Mild drowsiness, dry mouth	Most sedating 2nd-gen antihistamine.
Loratadine <i>Claritin</i>	2nd-Gen Antihistamine	Allergic rhinitis, hives	Blocks peripheral H1 receptors	Headache, minimal drowsiness	Once daily; non-sedating for most people.
Levocetirizine <i>Xyzal</i>	2nd-Gen Antihistamine	Allergic rhinitis, hives	Blocks peripheral H1 receptors	Drowsiness, dry mouth	Take in the evening.
Azelastine <i>Astelin / Astepro</i>	Intranasal Antihistamine	Allergic and nonallergic rhinitis	Blocks H1 receptors in the nose	Bitter taste, drowsiness, nasal irritation	Tilt head down while spraying to reduce bitter taste.

RENAL & ELECTROLYTES

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Oxybutynin <i>Ditropan</i>	Antimuscarinic (Bladder)	Overactive bladder	Blocks muscarinic receptors in the bladder	Dry mouth, constipation, confusion in older adults	Anticholinergic; avoid in older adults when possible (Beers).
Potassium Chloride <i>K-Dur / Klor-Con</i>	Electrolyte Supplement	Hypokalemia prevention and treatment	Replaces potassium	GI irritation, hyperkalemia	Take with food and a full glass of water; do not crush ER tabs.
Magnesium Salts <i>Mag-Ox</i>	Electrolyte Supplement	Low magnesium, constipation, heartburn	Replaces magnesium	Diarrhea; toxicity in kidney failure	Separate from many oral antibiotics.

VITAMINS & SUPPLEMENTS

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Ferrous Sulfate <i>Feosol</i>	Iron Supplement	Iron-deficiency anemia	Replaces iron for hemoglobin production	Constipation, dark stools, GI upset	Best on empty stomach with vitamin C. Keep away from children.
Melatonin <i>Various</i>	Sleep Aid / Supplement	Insomnia, jet lag	Mimics the natural sleep hormone	Drowsiness, headache, vivid dreams	Take 30-60 min before bed. Supplements are not FDA-regulated for dose accuracy.
Ergocalciferol (Vitamin D2) <i>Drisdol</i>	Vitamin	Vitamin D deficiency, hypoparathyroidism	Converted to active vitamin D; increases calcium absorption	Hypercalcemia with excess (nausea, weakness)	High-dose capsules are usually weekly.
Cholecalciferol (Vitamin D3) <i>Various</i>	Vitamin	Vitamin D deficiency, bone health	Converted to active vitamin D; increases calcium absorption	Hypercalcemia with excess	Fat-soluble; take with a meal containing fat.
Cyanocobalamin (Vitamin B12) <i>Nascobal</i>	Vitamin	B12 deficiency, pernicious anemia	Needed for red cell production and nerve function	Rare: injection-site pain, hypokalemia early in treatment	Pernicious anemia needs injection or nasal form.
Folic Acid <i>Folvite</i>	Vitamin (B9)	Folate deficiency, pregnancy (neural tube prevention), methotrexate	Needed for DNA synthesis and red cell production	Rarely: GI upset	Can mask B12 deficiency anemia.

EYE & SKIN

PHARMACOLOGY CHEAT SHEET

Top 200 Drugs

DRUG	CLASS	USES	MECHANISM	SIDE EFFECTS	NURSING NOTES
Brimonidine <i>Alphagan</i>	Alpha-2 Agonist (Eye)	Glaucoma, ocular hypertension	Reduces aqueous humor production	Eye redness, dry mouth, fatigue	Not for infants (CNS depression).
Ketoconazole <i>Nizoral</i> BOXED WARNING	Azole Antifungal (Topical)	Fungal skin infections, dandruff (topical)	Inhibits ergosterol synthesis	Topical: irritation. Oral: liver toxicity, QT prolongation	Oral use is limited due to hepatotoxicity; many interactions.
Timolol <i>Timoptic</i>	Beta Blocker (Eye)	Glaucoma	Reduces aqueous humor production	Eye stinging, bradycardia, bronchospasm	Systemic absorption possible; press on tear duct after drops.
Latanoprost <i>Xalatan</i>	Prostaglandin Analog (Eye)	Glaucoma, ocular hypertension	Increases aqueous humor outflow	Iris darkening, eyelash growth, eye redness	One drop at bedtime. Remove contacts; wait 15 min.
Clobetasol <i>Temovate</i>	Super-High-Potency Topical Steroid	Severe psoriasis, eczema	Reduces skin inflammation	Skin thinning, striae, HPA suppression	Limit to 2 weeks. Avoid face, groin, armpits.
Mupirocin <i>Bactroban</i>	Topical Antibiotic	Impetigo, MRSA nasal decolonization	Inhibits bacterial protein synthesis	Burning, itching at site	Apply thin layer; wash hands afterward.
Tretinoin <i>Retin-A</i>	Topical Retinoid	Acne, photoaging	Increases skin cell turnover	Dryness, peeling, sun sensitivity	Apply at night; use sunscreen. Avoid in pregnancy.

EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NOT A CLINICAL REFERENCE

This study aid is a learning and exam-review tool for nursing and pharmacy students. It must not be used to make patient-care decisions, including dosing, administration, or monitoring.

ALWAYS VERIFY

Drug information, boxed (black box) warnings, and high-alert designations change over time. Before applying anything in practice, check the current FDA-approved labeling, your facility's policies, and an up-to-date drug reference. Normal lab ranges vary between laboratories; use the ranges your program or facility provides.

RECOMMENDED REFERENCES FOR VERIFICATION

- FDA drug labels: DailyMed (dailymed.nlm.nih.gov)
- ISMP List of High-Alert Medications ([ismp.org](https://www.ismp.org))
- A current nursing drug handbook or your program's required drug reference
- Your course textbook and instructor guidance

ACCURACY

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